On Killing a Tree

The big idea

Gieve Patel's poem seems to give step-by-step instructions on how to **kill a tree**, but the tone is **ironic**. It shows the tree's amazing **resilience**: it grows slowly and heals itself, and the only way to kill it is to tear out its roots. The poem condemns human cruelty towards nature.

Summary

- **Stanza 1**: It takes much time to kill a tree. A simple **jab of the knife** will not do it. The tree has grown slowly, **consuming the earth**, absorbing years of **sunlight, air and water**, and out of its **leprous hide** sprouting leaves.
- **Stanza 2**: So **hack and chop**, but this alone will not do it. The bleeding bark will heal, and from close to the ground will rise **curled green twigs**, miniature boughs which, if unchecked, will expand again to former size.
- **Stanza 3**: No, the **root is to be pulled out**, out of the anchoring earth. It is to be tied, roped, pulled out, snapped out or pulled out entirely from the cave in the earth.
- **Stanza 4**: The strength of the tree is exposed: the source, **white and wet**, the most **sensitive**, hidden for years inside the earth. Then the matter of **scorching and choking** in sun and air, **browning, hardening, twisting, withering**. And then it is done.

IRONY

The poet sounds like an instruction manual, but he wants us to feel horror at the destruction. The tree's death is described like the slow, cruel killing of a living being.

Poetic devices

Device	Example
Irony	the whole poem; "And then it is done"
Personification	tree "bleeding bark", "leprous hide"
Metaphor	"leprous hide" (rough, patchy bark); "anchoring earth"
Alliteration	"**b**leeding **b**ark", "**w**hite and **w**et"
Imagery	"curled green twigs", "white and wet"
Free verse	no regular rhyme

THE POET DOES NOT WANT TREES KILLED

The "instructions" are ironic. The real message is that trees are living beings that fight to survive, and destroying them is cruel.

Themes and values

- **Resilience of nature**: a tree regrows from its stump.
- **Cruelty of humans**: deforestation is deliberate and thorough.
- Conserve trees; they took years to grow.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Why does a simple jab of the knife not kill a tree? What is the tree's real strength? What happens to the root when exposed? What is the tone of the poem?

Quick recap

- Cutting the trunk is not enough; the tree heals.

- Root must be pulled out and left to scorch and wither.
- Ironic tone; message: protect trees.

Practice questions

1. The poet of "On Killing a Tree" is

   (a) Gieve Patel (b) James Kirkup (c) Ruskin Bond (d) Vikram Seth

2. Why does a simple jab of the knife not kill a tree?

   (a) Trees cannot feel pain (b) The tree has grown slowly over years and can heal itself (c) Knives are too blunt (d) Trees are made of stone

3. "Leprous hide" refers to

   (a) diseased leaves (b) the roots (c) the rough, patchy bark of the tree (d) fallen branches

4. What happens if the tree is only hacked and chopped?

   (a) It dies immediately (b) It turns into stone (c) It falls over (d) Green twigs rise and grow it back to its former size

5. What finally kills the tree?

   (a) Cutting its leaves (b) Pulling out its root and leaving it to scorch and wither (c) Pouring water on it (d) Setting the trunk on fire

6. The tone of the poem is mainly

   (a) joyful (b) romantic (c) ironic (d) humorous

7. What is the strength of the tree? How is it finally killed?

Answers: 1. a 2. b 3. c 4. d 5. b 6. c 7. see notes